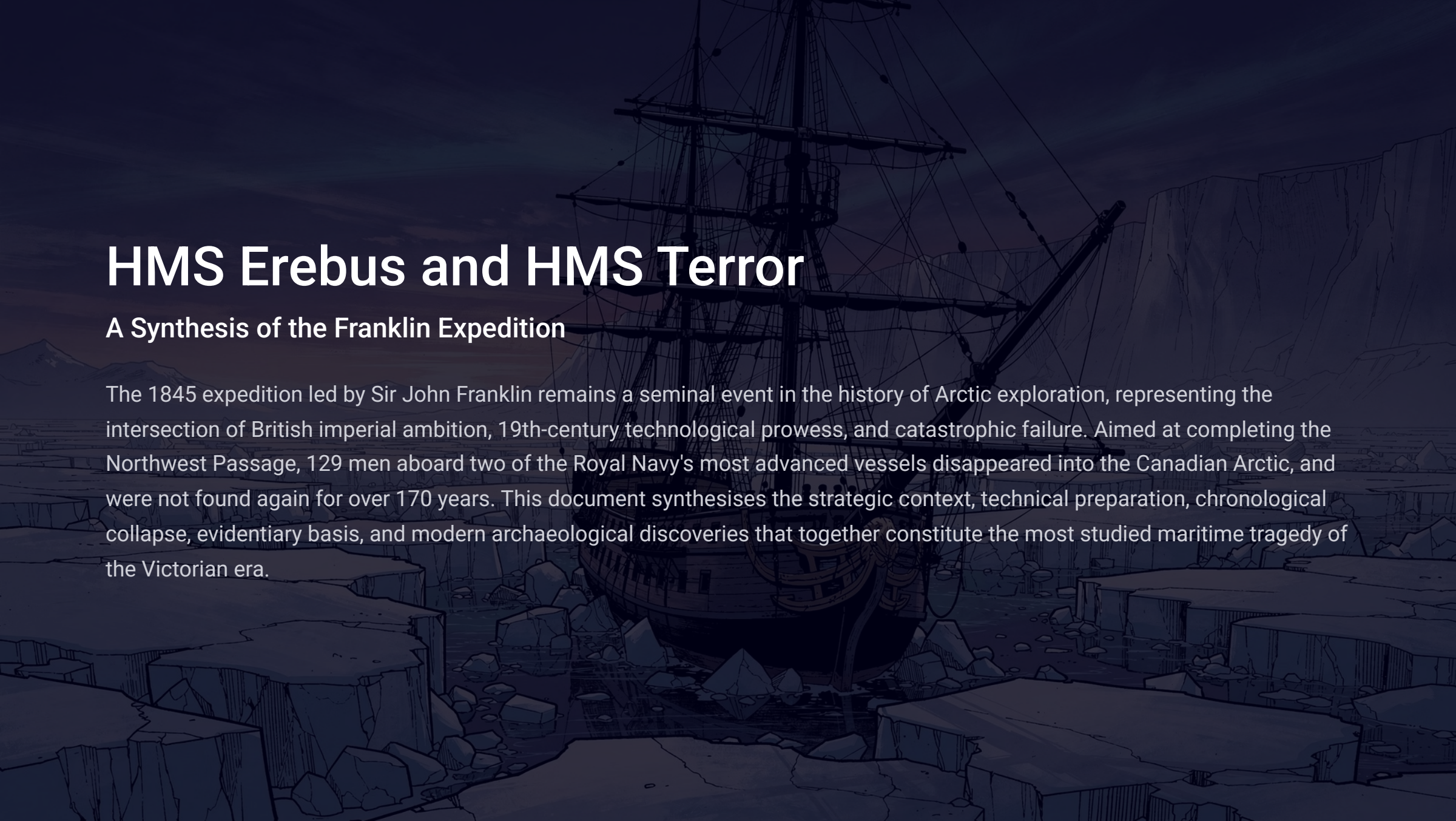


Into the Ice: The Franklin Expedition of 1845

The Disappearance of Sir John Franklin and the Fate of the Royal Navy's Finest

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HMS Erebus and HMS Terror

A Synthesis of the Franklin Expedition

The 1845 expedition led by Sir John Franklin remains a seminal event in the history of Arctic exploration, representing the intersection of British imperial ambition, 19th-century technological prowess, and catastrophic failure. Aimed at completing the Northwest Passage, 129 men aboard two of the Royal Navy's most advanced vessels disappeared into the Canadian Arctic, and were not found again for over 170 years. This document synthesises the strategic context, technical preparation, chronological collapse, evidentiary basis, and modern archaeological discoveries that together constitute the most studied maritime tragedy of the Victorian era.



I. Strategic Context and Objectives

The Franklin expedition was a high-stakes endeavour driven by the British Admiralty's post-Napoleonic focus on geographic prizes and naval science. With the Napoleonic Wars concluded, the Royal Navy found itself with both surplus officers and a renewed appetite for exploration as a form of productive imperial ambition. The Northwest Passage long imagined as a maritime link through the Canadian Arctic between the Atlantic and Pacific was valued as a potential shortcut for trade with Asia, sparing commercial vessels the arduous routes around the Cape of Good Hope or Cape Horn.

The Northwest Passage

A maritime link through the Canadian Arctic archipelago connecting Atlantic and Pacific waters. Long sought as a commercial shortcut to Asia, it represented the foremost remaining geographic prize of the age.

Imperial Prestige

The British government offered a £20,000 reward for the passage's discovery. Beyond financial gain, success was a matter of national prestige and the definitive resolution of a long-standing scientific and cartographic problem.

The Mission Objective

Sailing in May 1845, the expedition intended to connect known eastern Arctic waterways with charted western waters, effectively completing the map of the Northwest Passage and cementing British dominance in polar exploration.

The selection of Sir John Franklin to command the expedition reflected both his prior polar experience and his standing within the naval establishment. Franklin had previously led overland Arctic expeditions in 1819 and 1825, though those journeys had been marked by severe hardship. The confidence with which the Admiralty despatched the 1845 mission with 129 men and three years of provisions speaks to an institutional conviction that technological advancement had fundamentally altered the calculus of polar risk. That confidence would prove tragically misplaced.